

Chapter 43: When Staying Starts to Mean Something

Jenny didn't like how quiet he had become.

Not silent.

Not distant.

Just... steady.

Austin was still there, same place, same posture, same presence.

But something about him had stopped bending around her uncertainty.

And that changed everything.

The restaurant was closing soon.

Most customers had left.

Chairs were being stacked.

The air felt thinner, like the day was winding itself down too carefully.

Jenny wiped the counter even though it was already clean.

A habit.

A shield.

Something to keep her hands busy while her mind wasn't ready.

Austin spoke first.

"You're avoiding looking at me."

Jenny didn't stop wiping.

"I'm working."

"You always say that when you're not answering something."

That made her pause.

Slowly, she looked up.

"...What do you want me to say?"

Austin didn't hesitate.

"Something honest."

Jenny let out a short breath.

"That's becoming your favorite word."

"Because it's the only one that matters right now," he said.

Silence settled between them.

Not heavy.

Not light.

Just present.

Jenny finally asked,

"Do you ever think this is too much?"

Austin looked at her.

"Yes."

That immediate answer surprised her.

Then he added,

"But I think pretending it's less would be worse."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"...Worse for who?"

"For both of us," he said.

A pause.

"Especially you."

That made her still.

Jenny set the cloth down.

"You keep saying things like you understand me."

Austin shook his head slightly.

"I don't understand everything."

A pause.

"But I understand what happens when someone feels something they don't know how to hold."

Silence.

That landed too close again.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"You're making it sound like I'm avoiding you."

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"I think you're avoiding what it would mean if you didn't."

That sentence stayed in the air longer than anything else today.

Jenny looked away.

Of course she did.

After a moment, she said quietly,

"You came back different."

"Yes," Austin said.

"And you're not going back."

"No," he agreed.

That simplicity unsettled her more than argument would have.

Jenny exhaled.

"So what now?"

Austin looked at her for a long moment.

Then—

"Now I don't shrink this anymore."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"...Shrink what?"

"This," he said.

And he didn't gesture.

He didn't need to.

Silence.

Jenny felt it again.

That shift.

Not emotional chaos.

Not drama.

But structure forming where there used to be ambiguity.

And she wasn't sure she liked it.

"You're moving too fast," she said quietly.

Austin nodded.

"I know."

"Then why not slow down?"

A pause.

Then—

"Because I've already slowed down for too long."

That made her look at him again.

Jenny hesitated.

"You make it sound like I'm the one holding this back."

Austin didn't deny it.

"I think you're trying to keep it safe."

Jenny frowned.

"...And you think that's wrong?"

"No," he said.

A pause.

"I think it's understandable."

That softened the edge slightly.

Then he added,

"But I don't think I can stay inside something that only survives when it's half-hidden."

Silence.

That changed the tone completely.

Jenny felt her chest tighten.

"So you're saying if I don't... define this, you won't stay the same way?"

Austin looked at her.

"I'm saying I won't pretend I'm not already here fully."

That distinction mattered.

Too much.

Jenny looked down.

"I don't know what 'fully' means for me."

Austin nodded.

"I know."

A pause.

Then softer—

"But I do."

Silence.

That was the first time the imbalance became visible.

Not emotional.

Structural.

Jenny finally said,

"This feels like an ultimatum."

Austin shook his head immediately.

"It isn't."

A pause.

"It's honesty about direction, not pressure about choice."

Jenny looked at him.

"...That still feels like pressure."

"I understand," he said.

But he didn't retract anything.

A long silence followed.

The restaurant was almost empty now.

Lights slightly dimmer.

Noise fading into the background of ending shifts.

Jenny spoke quietly.

"I don't want to lose what we have."

Austin nodded.

"I know."

"But I don't know how to step into what you're calling it."

A pause.

Then he said softly,

"Then don't step yet."

Jenny looked up slightly.

"...What?"

Austin held her gaze.

"Just don't step away either."

Silence.

That wasn't a demand.

It wasn't a push.

It was something else.

Stability offered instead of imposed.

Jenny felt her breath slow slightly.

For the first time in days, the pressure didn't increase.

It shifted.

Not away.

Not toward.

Just... held.

She whispered,

"That sounds impossible."

Austin nodded once.

"It is."

A pause.

Then quietly—

"But so is what we've already built."

Silence.

Jenny didn't respond.

But she didn't leave the space either.

And for now...

that was enough.